

Introductory note:

This Chinese literature course introduces major developments in Chinese literary history from the 16th century to the present while engaging upper-division undergraduate students in research in Chinese Studies through critical discussion and small-scale projects. It also emphasizes media awareness and digital literacy by integrating critical engagement with media forms and digital culture into classroom practice. While English translations of selected works of Chinese adventure literature are used, students are encouraged to consult the Chinese originals whenever possible. Students further examine transmedia and multimodal adaptations of these works—including theatrical performances, films, and video games—to analyze how literature is reimagined across media forms and endowed with new aesthetic and cultural meanings.

Because the primary audience consists of Generation Z students who have grown up in multimedia environments, the course places particular importance on equipping them with critical tools to navigate the media ecologies that shape their daily lives. Incorporating popular digital media into the study of Chinese literature also helps foster engagement, as many contemporary cultural products are deeply rooted in classical and modern literary traditions. In turn, what students learn in this course is connected to contemporary China, enabling them to develop the cultural competence necessary for real-world transcultural communication and understanding. This competence supports their professional, civic, and personal lives well beyond the classroom.

Syllabus:**Adventures in Chinese Fiction, Film, and Video Games**

Instructor: Xuezhao Li

Course Description

Adventure has been a recurring theme in Chinese fiction, spanning gods-and-demons fiction, science fiction, martial arts fiction, alongside the less-developed genre of adventure fiction, and inspiring adaptations into film and video games. This course covers Chinese adventure narratives across media from the 16th century to the present, tracing evolving portrayals of adventure and heroism within shifting historical and cultural contexts. It integrates close readings of literary texts (in English) with narrative analysis of adventure films and video games, grounded in theories of adaptation studies. Discussion topics include: the rise of genre fiction and the underdevelopment of adventure fiction; transmedia adaptations at the intersection of propaganda, entertainment, and popular culture in the context of evolving Chinese film and video game industries; representations of cultural and national selfhood and otherness in adventure encounters; science adventure's links to colonial modernity, nationalism, and planetarianism; contemporary adventure fiction and online literature; and gender politics in these predominantly masculinist genres.

Course Goals

1. Identify the defining conventions of gods-and-demons, martial arts, science, and adventure fiction, and place a text not studied in class within that genre landscape, justifying the placement with textual evidence.
2. Explain how a specific historical transition — the late Qing encounter with the West, the Maoist period, the post-1990s turn to commercial media — shaped the form and content of a genre text studied in the course.
3. Apply a named concept from adaptation theory (fidelity, transposition, transmedia storytelling, remediation) to compare a source text with one of its film or video game adaptations.
4. Construct an argument about modernity, cultural and national identity, or gender politics in a course text, supported by close reading and at least two scholarly sources.
5. Produce a research essay, independently or collaboratively, that poses its own question, selects its own primary material, and situates its claim within existing scholarship.

Assessment

1. Reading journals: Students will keep a weekly journal of assigned readings, which records their critical reflections.
2. Small project showcase: Students will give in-class presentations on case studies related to the weekly topic, focusing on film and video game adaptations of Chinese adventure fiction.
3. Short essays: Students will submit two short essays on topics related to the course. At least one essay must apply theories of adaptation in its analysis, and students may choose to write on the same topic as one of their class presentations.
4. Final Project: Students will complete a long formal essay as their final project and deliver an oral presentation at the end of the semester.

Weighting and Alignment:

Component	Weight
Reading journals (weekly)	15%
Small project showcases (2 presentations)	15%
Short essays (2 × 15%)	30%
Final project — oral presentation	10%
Final project — formal essay	30%

Alignment. Reading journals assess Goals 1 and 2. The showcases and the first short essay assess Goal 3. The second short essay assesses Goal 4. The final project assesses Goals 4 and 5.

Weekly Schedule (two classes each week)

Week One:

Class 1: Introduction to the Course

In-class discussions of the syllabus, including course goals and assessment methods, and an overview of expectations for each session.

Class 2: Introduction to Chinese Adventure Fiction

A brief genealogy of modern Chinese literary history, and discussions on the definition of adventure literature and its place within Chinese literary history.

Readings:

Green, Martin. *Seven Types of Adventure Tale: An Etiology of a Major Genre*. University Park: The Pennsylvania State University Press, 1991. (Preface, pp. 1-24)

Denton, Kirk A. "Historical Overview." In *The Columbia Companion to Modern Chinese Literature*, edited by Kirk A. Denton, 3–26. New York: Columbia University Press, 2016.

Unit One: Adventure in Gods-and-demons Fiction: the 16th -19th Centuries

Week Two:

Class 1: Gods-and-demons Fiction and *Xiyou ji* (The Journey to the West)

An introduction to Chinese gods-and-demons fiction and class discussions based on close readings of *The Journey to the West*, with a focus on representations of the self and the other in adventure encounters.

Readings:

Wu, Cheng'en. *The Journey to the West*. Translated by Anthony C. Yu. Vol. 1. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press, 2012. Chapter 65.

Cozad, Laurie. "Reeling in the Demon: An Exploration into the Category of the Demonized Other as Portrayed in *The Journey to the West*." *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 66, no. 1 (1998): 117–145.

Class 2: *Black Myth: Wukong* and Literary Adaptations into Video Games

Narrative analyses of the storylines featured in *Black Myth: Wukong* (students will watch related gameplay or trailer videos in advance), alongside practical applications of adaptation studies to examine the transformation of *The Journey to the West* into *Black Myth: Wukong*.

Readings:

Flanagan, Kevin M. "Videogame Adaptation." In *The Oxford Handbook of Adaptation Studies*, Thomas Leitch (ed), 441–458. New York: Oxford University Press, 2017.

Hutcheon, Linda. *A Theory of Adaptation*. New York: Routledge, 2006. Chapter 1, "Beginning to Theorize Adaptation: What? Who? Why? How? Where? When?" pp. 1-32.

Week Three:

Class 1: A Qing-dynasty Gods-and-demons Novel: *Jing hua yuan* (Flowers in the Mirror)

Class discussions based on close readings of *Flowers in the Mirror*, with a focus on the world order and gender order expressed in the work.

Readings:

Li, Ju-chen. *Flowers in the Mirror*. Translated and edited by Lin Tai-yi. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1965. Chapters 12-15, pp. 95-132.

Epstein, Maram. "Engendering Order: Structure, Gender, and Meaning in the Qing Novel *Jinghua Yuan*." *Chinese Literature: Essays, Articles, Reviews (CLEAR)* 18 (1996): 101–127.

Class 2: Small Project Showcase

Brief in-class presentations: A case study of one video game (original or adaptation) that incorporates Chinese adventurous elements, which may be produced in China or other countries. Suggested games include *Where Winds Meet*, *Monkey King: Hero Is Back*, *Wo Long: Fallen Dynasty*, *GuJian 3*, and *Dynasty Warriors 9*—all available in English.

Unit Two: Adventure in Modern Travel Fiction, Adventure Fiction and Science Fiction: 1840-1949

Week Four:

Class 1: Modern Travel Fiction, First Sino-West Contact, and Gender Politics

An introduction to late Qing travel fiction, with class discussions centered on close readings of Wang Tao's short stories, focusing on their representations of early Sino-Western encounters and the gender politics embedded in their narratives.

Readings:

Wang, Tao. "A Great Overseas Adventure," and "A Wonderland under the Sea." Translated by Xuezhao Li. *Renditions*, no. 100 (2024): 80–94.

Zheng, Huili. "Enchanted Encounter: Gender Politics, Cultural Identity, and Wang Tao's (1828–97) Fictional Sino-Western Romance", *Nan Nü* 16, no. 2 (2014): 274-307.

Class 2: The Underdevelopment of Modern Chinese Adventure Fiction

I will share my research findings on modern Chinese adventure fiction and related (unpublished) translated works with students, and lead discussions on the challenges of genre categorization in the late Qing and early Republican periods, as well as the relative underdevelopment of original Chinese adventure fiction.

Readings:

He, Jiong. *Lion Blood*. Translated by Xuezhao Li. Unpublished excerpts.

Isaacson, Nathaniel. *Celestial Empire: The Emergence of Chinese Science Fiction*. Middletown: Wesleyan University Press, 2017. Chapter 1, "Genre Trouble," pp.1-27.

Week Five:

Class 1: Translation and Modern Chinese Genre Fiction

Class discussions on how the translation of Western and Japanese literatures contributed to the formation and development of modern Chinese genre fiction, with particular attention to the shaping power of translation over modern Chinese adventure fiction (about which I will share my research findings).

Readings:

Jiang, Qian. "Translation and the Development of Science Fiction in Twentieth-Century China." *Science Fiction Studies* 40, no. 1 (2013): 116–132.

Pollard, David E. "Introduction." In *Translation and Creation: Readings of Western Literature in Early Modern China, 1840–1918*, edited by David E. Pollard, 5–24. Amsterdam: J. Benjamins, 1998.

Class 2: Modern Chinese Science Fiction and Colonial Modernity

An introduction to modern Chinese science fiction and class discussions based on close readings of a late Qing short story "New Tales of Mr. Braggadocio," with a focus on science adventure's connections with colonial modernity in semi-colonial China.

Readings:

Xu, Nianci. "New Tales of Mr. Braggadocio." Translated by Nathaniel Isaacson. *Renditions*, no. 78 (2012): 15–38.

Isaacson, Nathaniel. *Celestial Empire: The Emergence of Chinese Science Fiction*. Middletown: Wesleyan University Press, 2017. Chapter 4, "SF for the Nation," pp. 93–107.

Week Six:

Class 1: Encounter with the World in Adventure: *Xin shitou ji* (New Story of the Stone)

Class discussions based on close readings of *New Story of the Stone*, with a focus on how its utopian adventures deal with late Qing China's anxieties during its encounter with the rest of the world, especially the challenges from the West.

Readings:

Wu, Jianren. *New Story of the Stone: An Early Chinese Science Fiction Novel*. Translated by Liz Evans Weber. New York: Columbia University Press, 2025. Chapter 31–32, 383–409

Huters, Theodore. *Bringing the World Home: Appropriating the West in Late Qing and Early Republican China*. Honolulu: University of Hawai'i Press, 2005 Chapter 6, "Melding East and West: Wu Jianren's *New Story of the Stone*," pp. 151–172.

Class 2: Encounter with Aliens in Adventure: *Maocheng ji* (Cat Country)

Class discussions based on close readings of *Cat Country*, with a focus on the connection between its satire and colonial modernity, between the depiction of alterity and national character criticism.

Readings:

Lao She. *Cat Country*. Translated by William A. Lyell. With an introduction by Ian Johnson. New York: Penguin Books, 2013.

Raphals, Lisa. "Alterity and Alien Contact in Lao She's Martian Dystopia, *Cat Country*." *Science Fiction Studies* 40, no. 1 (2013): 73–85.

First short essay due.

Unit Three: Adventure in Martial Arts Fiction and Film: 1950s-1990s

Week Seven:

Class 1: Martial Arts Fiction and *Legends of the Condor Heroes*

Close readings of *A Hero Born: Legends of the Condor Heroes*, and class discussions focused on its spatial representation and ideas of nationalism.

Readings:

Jin Yong, *A Hero Born: Legends of the Condor Heroes, Volume 1*, Translated by Anna Holmwood (New York: St. Martin's Press, 2019). Chapter 7, pp. 319-371.

Song, Weijie. "Jin Yong's Method of Imagining China." *Chinese Literature Today* 8, no. 2 (2019): 77–83.

Class 2: Martial Arts Film and Literary Adaptations into Films

A historical overview of Chinese martial arts fiction and film, followed by critical discussions of the 1977 film *The Brave Archer*—an adaptation of *Legends of the Condor Heroes*—using adaptation theory. Students will watch the film before class.

Readings:

Teo, Stephen. *Chinese Martial Arts Cinema: The Wuxia Tradition*. Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2015. Chapter 1, "Wuxia from Literature to Cinema," pp. 17-36; Chapter 4, "The Rise of New School Wuxia," pp 84-111.

Film:

The Brave Archer. Directed by Chang Cheh. Hong Kong: Shaw Brothers Studio, 1977.

Week Eight:

Class 1: Another Film Adaptation: *Ashes of Time* (1994) by Wong Kar Wai

Class discussions on the following questions: how this film creatively adapted the story of *A Hero Born*? How do you understand the presence or absence of the adventure narrative in this film? How does the formal and stylistic experimentation in this film represent the new trends in Hong Kong's film industry in the 1990s? Students will watch the film before class.

Readings:

Dissanayake, Wimal, and Dorothy Wong. *Wong Kar-Wai's Ashes of Time*. Hong Kong: Hong Kong University Press, 2003. Chapter 1-3, pp. 1-34.

Zhou, Juanita Huan. "Ashes of Time: The Tragedy and Salvation of the Chinese Intelligentsia." *Asian Cinema* 10, no. 1 (1998): 62-70.

Class 2: Small Project Showcase

Brief in-class presentations: a case study of one film adaptation of martial arts fiction with adventurous elements, from any production period.

Unit Four: Adventure in Contemporary SF Stories, SF Films, and Other Adventure Films: the 21st Century

Week Nine:

Class 1: Contemporary Science Fiction and Liu Cixin's Works

An introduction to contemporary Chinese science fiction and representative works by Liu Cixin, as well as class discussions based on close readings of *Liulang diqiu* (The Wandering Earth), with a focus on literary extrospection and planetarianism.

Readings:

Liu, Cixin. *The Wandering Earth*. Translated by Ken Liu, et al. London: Head of Zeus, 2017. pp. 1-46.

Song, Mingwei. *Fear of Seeing: A Poetics of Chinese Science Fiction*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2023. Prologue and Chapter 1, "Poetics of the Invisible: Introducing the New Wave," pp. 1-42.

Class 2: The Film Adaptation of *The Wandering Earth*

Class discussions on the adaptation of *The Wandering Earth* into the 2019 eponymous film, with particular attention to the interplay between nationalism and planetarianism, and the shaping forces of propaganda and commercial entertainment. Students will watch the film before class.

Readings:

Zhu, Ping. "From Patricide to Patrilineality: Adapting *The Wandering Earth* for the Big Screen." *Arts* 9, no. 3 (2020): 94-105.

Wang, Zhuoyi. "Between the World Ship and the Spaceship: Planetarianism, Hollywood, Nationalism, and the Iceberg-Shaped Story of *The Wandering Earth* (2019)." *Prism: Theory and Modern Chinese Literature* 18, no. 1 (2021): 210-234.

Film:

The Wandering Earth. Directed by Frant Gwo. Beijing: China Film Group Corporation, 2019.

Week Ten:

Class 1: Another Version of Wandering in Universe: *Santi III: Sishen yongsheng* (Death's End, The Three-Body Problem Series, 3)

Class discussions based on close readings of *Death's End*, with a focus on how scientific fantasy explores the boundaries of adventure and fuzzes the line between self and the other.

Readings:

Liu, Cixin. *Death's End*. Translated by Ken Liu. New York: Tom Doherty Associates, LLC, 2016. Part V.

Shanahan, John. 2024. "Troubling the Anthropos in the Post-anthropocene: Liu Cixin's *Three-Body* Trilogy." In *Spatial Futures*, edited by L. E. Eaves, H. J. Nast, and A. G. Papadopoulos, 479–512. Singapore: Palgrave Macmillan.

Class 2: The Possibility of Screen Adaptations of the Three-Body Problem Series

Class discussions of the Netflix TV drama adaptation "3-Body Problem, Season 1," its Chinese counterpart, and an animated version of the second book in this series, all of which are grappling with the challenge of visualization. The discussions center on how narrative and visual expressions are articulated across different adaptations, and on whether textual forms possess an inherently irreplaceable capacity for meaning-making compared to other media, or if such distinctions merely reflect unresolved technological constraints.

Readings:

Shcherbino, Ksenia. "3 Body Problem." *Foundation* 53, no. 149 (2024): 113-116.

Drama series/Animated films:

3 Body Problem. Directed by David Benioff, D. B. Weiss, and Alexander Woo. Netflix, 2024.

Santi (Three-Body Problem). Directed by Yang Lei. Tencent Video, 2023.

Shuidi (Waterdrop). Directed by Wang Ren. 2015. Short animation.

Week Eleven:

Class 1: The Adaptation of Mao-era Fiction into Commercial Adventure Film

A comparative analysis of the 1967 model theater adaptation and the 2014 film version of the Mao-era revolutionary novel *Linhai xueyuan* (Tracks in the Snowy Forest), focusing on the intersections of political ideology, cultural identity, and commercial strategy in contemporary reinterpretations of Maoist literature. Students will watch the film before class.

Readings:

Van Fleit Hang, Krista. *Literature the People Love: Reading Chinese Texts from the Early Maoist Period (1949–1966)*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2013. Chapter 4, "The Heart of the Party: Gender and Communist Party Ideals in *Tracks in the Snowy Forest*," pp. 91-118.

Zhang, Zoe Yi. "Remake as Resistance: Re-narrating Hong Kong Chineseness in *The Taking of Tiger Mountain*." *Adaptation* 18, no. 1 (2025): Article apae028, 1-21.

Films/Theater plays:

The Taking of Tiger Mountain. Directed by Tsui Hark. Beijing: Bona Film Group et al., 2014.

Linhai xueyuan (Tracks in the Snowy Forest). Model Peking Opera. Beijing: 1967.

Class 2: Contemporary Chinese Western Adventures: *Wuren qu* (No Man's Land) (2013)

Based on a narrative analysis of the film *No Man's Land*, class discussions focus on how adventure narratives took new forms in contemporary Chinese “Western films” and the social class, ethnic, and ecocritical issues behind them.

Readings:

Qian, Kun. “No Man’s Land: Eco-Western in Contemporary Chinese Cinema.” In *Ecology and Chinese-Language Cinema: Reimagining a Field*, edited by Sheldon H. Lu and Haomin Gong, 223–237. 1st ed. New York: Routledge, 2019.

Film:

No Man's Land. Directed by Ning Hao. Beijing: China Film Group Co., Ltd., 2013.

Second short essay due.

Unit Five: Contemporary Adventure Fiction, Online Fiction, and IP Media Ecology: the 21st Century

Week Twelve:

Class 1: Contemporary Adventure Fiction as a Subgenre of Online Fiction

An introduction to Chinese online fiction and contemporary adventure fiction, particularly the grave-robbing adventure novel series, and class discussions based on close readings of *Gui chui deng I: Jingjue gucheng* (*The City of Sand*, Ghost Blows Out the Light Series, 1), with a focus on various factors contributing to the subgenre’s popularity: the rise of online literary platforms, new modes of literary consumption, frequent media adaptations, etc.

Readings:

Tianxia Bachang. *The City of Sand* (Ghost Blows Out the Light Series, 1). Translated by Jeremy Tiang. New York: Random House Children's Books, 2017. Prologue and Chapter 1-4, pp. 1-40.

Lugg, Alexander. “Chinese Online Fiction: Taste Publics, Entertainment, and *Candle in the Tomb*.” *Chinese Journal of Communication* 4, no. 2 (2011): 121–136.

Class 2: A Film Adaptation: *Xun long jue* (Mojin-The Lost Legend) (2015)

Class discussions on the adaptation of *Ghost Blows Out the Light* into the film *Mojin-The Lost Legend*, with a focus on its political and ethnical discourses and how they are balanced with the elements of adventure and fantasy in the film.

Readings:

Ma, Sheng-Mei. “China’s Orient in *Fin de Siècle* Culture.” In *Orientalism and Reverse Orientalism in Literature and Film: Beyond East and West*, edited by Sharmani Patricia Gabriel and Bernard Wilson, 160–175. 1st ed. New York: Routledge, 2021.

Film:

Xun long jue (Mojin-The Lost Legend). Directed by Wuershan. Beijing: Wanda Cinema Line Corp, 2015.

Week Thirteen:

Class 1: Contemporary Adventure Fiction and IP Adaptations

An introduction to the concept of IP adaptations, and class discussions centered on close readings of *Daomu biji I: Qixing lu wang* (Cavern of the Blood Zombies, Grave Robbers' Chronicles, 1), focusing on the Grave Robbers' Chronicles series' transmedia adaptations and the role of fandom culture in its development. Students will watch some clips of TV adaptations of this novel before class.

Readings:

Xu, Lei. *Cavern of the Blood Zombies* (Grave Robbers' Chronicles, 1). Translated by Kathy Mok. San Francisco: ThingsAsian Press, 2025. Chapter 1-4, pp. 1-46.

Stevens, E. Charlotte. "Chinese (Pseudo)Archaeology on Television: A *Daomu Biji* Case Study." In *The Routledge Handbook of Archaeology and the Media in the 21st Century*, edited by Lorna-Jane Richardson, Andrew Reinhard, and Nicole Smith, 90–103. London: Routledge, 2024.

Class 2: Contemporary Adventure Fiction and *Danmei/baihe* Culture

Class discussions on the connection between the grave-robbing adventure novel and *danmei/baihe* reading cultures, and on the gender politics those cultures carry.

Readings:

Yang, Ling, and Yanrui Xu. "'Opening the Door to a New World': *Danmei* and the Gender Revolution in China." In *The Routledge Handbook of Chinese Gender & Sexuality*, edited by Jamie J. Zhao and Hongwei Bao, 225–239. London: Routledge, 2024.

Ni, Zhange. "Lesbian Fetishes, Queer Archaeology, and the Fusion of *Baihe* and *Daomu* in Explore Fictitious Tombs (Tanxuling)." *Chinese Literature and Thought Today* 55, no. 3–4 (2024): 71–83.

Week Fourteen:

Class 1: Final Project Presentations, Part I

In this session, students present their final projects (completed or in progress) to the class, introducing their research questions, findings, and critical questions.

Class 2: Final Project Presentations, Part II

In this session, students continue to present their final projects.